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Valence Asymmetries in Moral Judgements

Michelle Stanković

Morgan Moyer & Isidora Stojanovic



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**Universitat
Pompeu Fabra
Barcelona**



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Overview

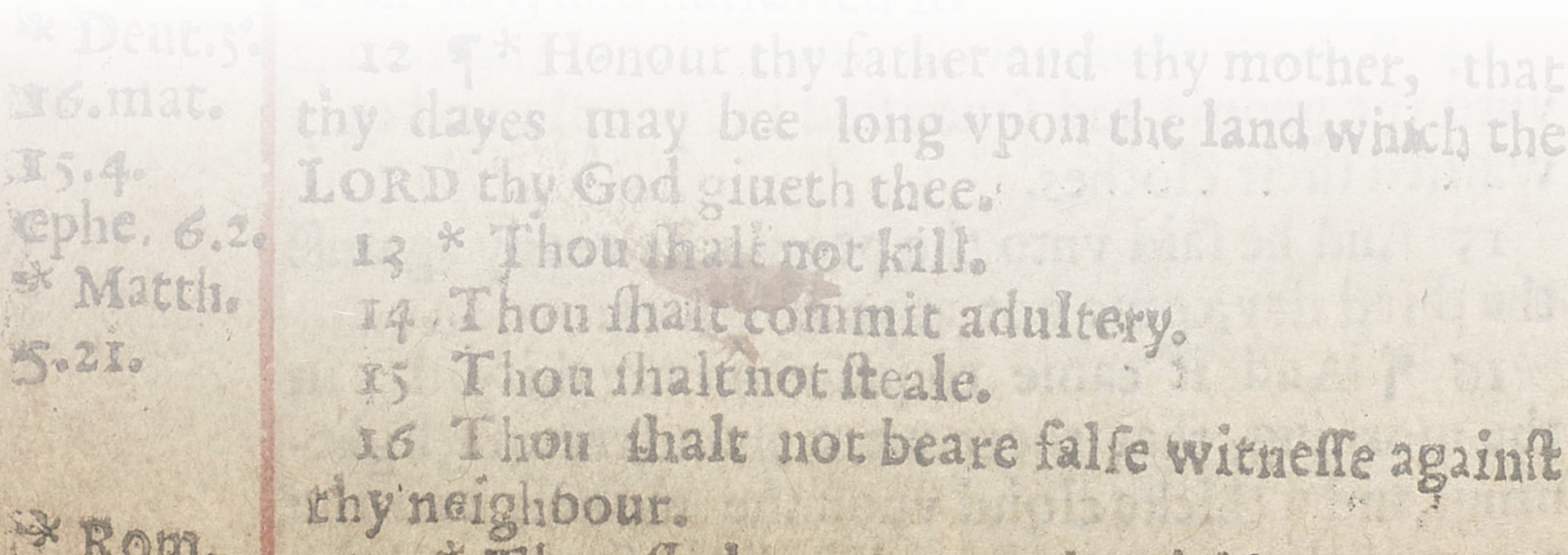
- Valence and Moral Judgements: Objectivity
- Background: Goodwin & Darley (2012)
- Our Study:
- Stimuli and study design
- Data: Two (very) recent pilot studies

Currently:

- Many issues with the materials
- Many issues with the data

Morality & Valence

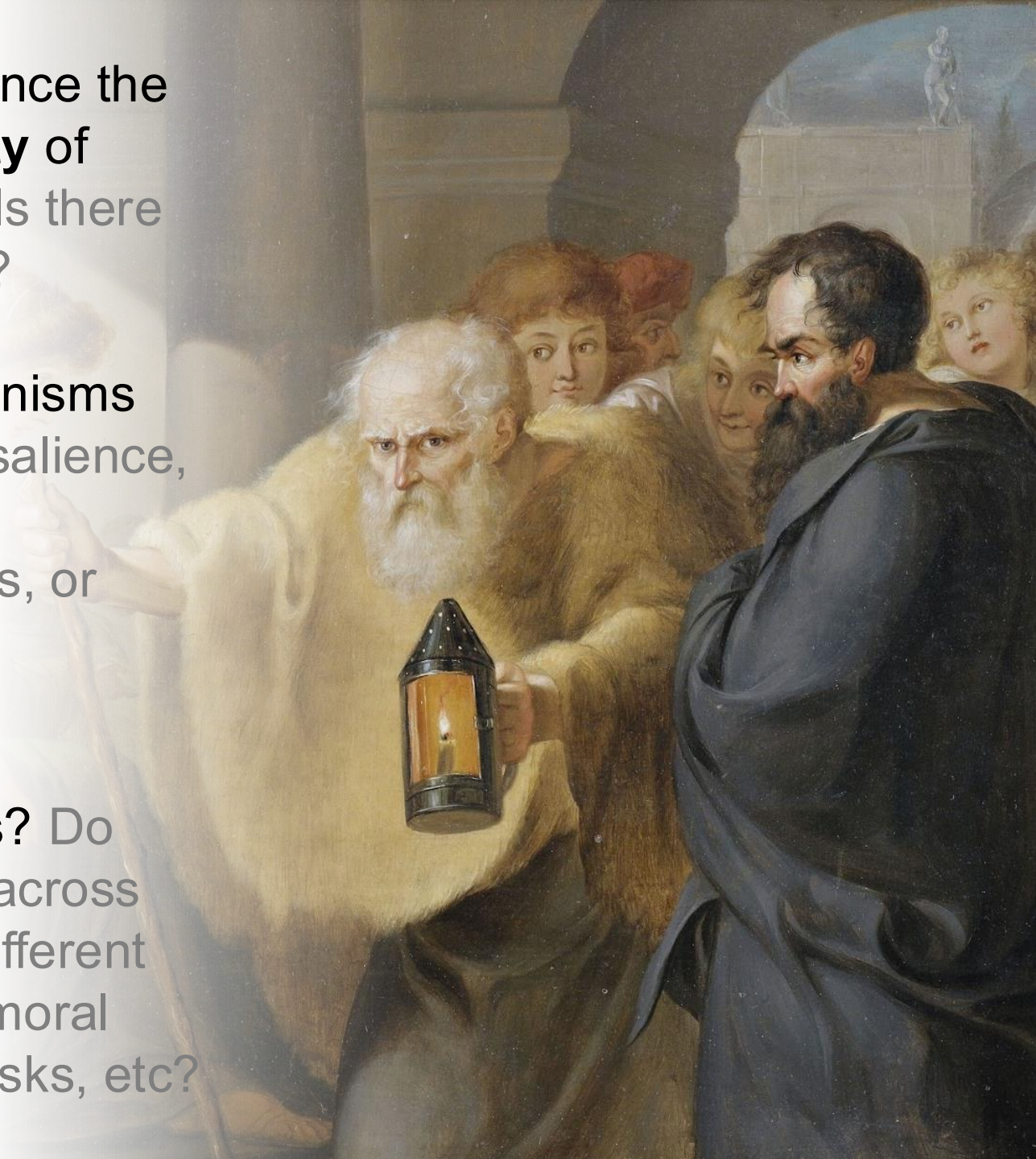
- Higher focus on proscriptive norms
 - Preventing harm
- Higher focus on blame (vs. praise)
- Religion, Law



Does **valence** influence the perceived **objectivity** of moral judgements? Is there a stable asymmetry?

What are the mechanisms responsible? Norm salience, target-directedness, perceived consensus, or perceived objective grounding?

Boundary conditions? Do these patterns hold across bilingual contexts, different adjective framings, moral actions, response tasks, etc?



Background: Goodwin & Darley

- Moral beliefs are less objective than facts, but more objective than beliefs about social conventions and taste
- Negative immoral acts are seen as more objective than positive moral acts
- Perceived consensus predicts objectivity

Table 1
The mean objectivity ratings for the moral items in Study 1.

⑥

VS.

③

	Negative acts						Positive acts			Contested value of life issues		
	1. Steal wallet	2. Punch	3. False alibi	4. Urinate on memorial	5. Nazi salute	6. Burn Flag	7. Swim rescue	8. Donate income	9. Eco consumerism	10. Abortion	11. Assisted Death	12. Turn off life support
Objectivity	5.43 _a	4.89 _b	4.73 _{b,c}	5.05 _b	4.87 _b	4.51 _c	4.43 _{c,d}	4.10 _{d,e}	3.79 _e	3.28 _f	3.09 _{f,g}	2.88 _g

Note. Cells that do not share the same lettered sub-script are significantly different from each other at the $p < .05$ level.

Wrong?

Good?

Goodwin & Darley (2012)

One of Megan's best friends is being charged with murder. Megan is convinced that he is innocent, although she does not know what he was doing on the night of the alleged murder. Without having been asked, Megan provides a false alibi to the police for her friend, claiming that she was with him on the night of the night of the alleged murder. Rate the extent to which you agree with the claim that Megan's actions are morally *wrong*.

Sarah is sunbathing at the beach on a day off work. She notices that a small crowd has gathered on the shore, which is pointing to a swimmer who has been caught in a rip current, and appears to be drowning. There are no lifeguards at this particular beach. Sarah joins the crowd, and they try to decide what to do. Sarah is only a moderately strong swimmer, and probably not the strongest in the group. But, since no- one is taking any action, Sarah volunteers to swim out to the swimmer. She manages to reach the swimmer and succeeds in bringing him to safety. Rate the extent to which you agree with the claim that Sarah's actions are morally *good*.

Goodwin & Darley (2012)

Problems:

- Vignettes
 - Not many positive actions
 - Different content across valence
- Framing: Compared wrongness with goodness
- Measuring Objectivity: Aggregated two questions

Positive Vignettes:

1. An OK swimmer rescues some who is drowning
2. Anonymously donating 10% income to charity
3. Buying a more expensive eco-friendly car

Negative Vignettes:

1. Steal wallet
2. Punch man at bar
3. Give police false alibi for a friend
4. Urinate on a 9/11 memorial
5. Do a Nazi salute
6. Burn a US flag

Research Questions

- Does valence impact objectivity? Can we replicate Goodwin and Darley's findings?
 - Measure 1: Correct Answer
 - Measure 2: Disagreement
- Does response wording matter?
 - wrong/right – very? completely?
 - bad/good
- Does perceived consensus and ease help explain objectivity judgements?

Design

- Participants see 10 vignettes
 - Each participant sees 5 pos and 5 neg
 - Valence counterbalanced, order randomised
- Participants answer 5 questions:
 1. How would you judge this person's actions?
 2. Do you think there is a correct answer about how to judge this person's actions?
 3. How many people in your community would agree with your judgement?
 4. How easy was it for you to make this judgement?
 5. If you found out that another person had significantly disagreed with you, would they be mistaken?

Please read the following story and then answer the questions below.

Anna wants to buy a new car for her daily commute.

She can buy a cheaper petrol model or a more expensive hybrid that is better for the environment.

Both meet her needs equally well and she can afford both, although she would prefer to save some money for other things. Anna buys the cheaper petrol car.

Pilot 1



How would you judge this person's actions?

- ☐ Very wrong
- ☐ Wrong
- ☐ Somewhat wrong
- ☐ Somewhat right
- ☐ Right
- ☐ Very right

Pilot 2



- ☐ Completely wrong
- ☐ Mostly wrong
- ☐ Wrong
- ☐ Somewhat wrong
- ☐ Somewhat right
- ☐ Right
- ☐ Mostly right
- ☐ Completely right

Design

Q1: How would you judge this person's actions?

- Participants assigned to *either*:
 - Good-Bad Framing
 - Right-Wrong Framing
- Pilot 1: 6-pt scale
 - Very Good-Very Bad
 - Very Right-Very Wrong
- Pilot 2: 8-pt scale
 - Extremely Good-Extremely Bad
 - Completely Right-Completely Wrong

Valence & Objectivity

- Objectivity:
 - Is there a correct answer?
 - Is the other person mistaken?
- Goodwin and Darley's (2012) asymmetry: *not replicated*
- Two objectivity measures behave differently

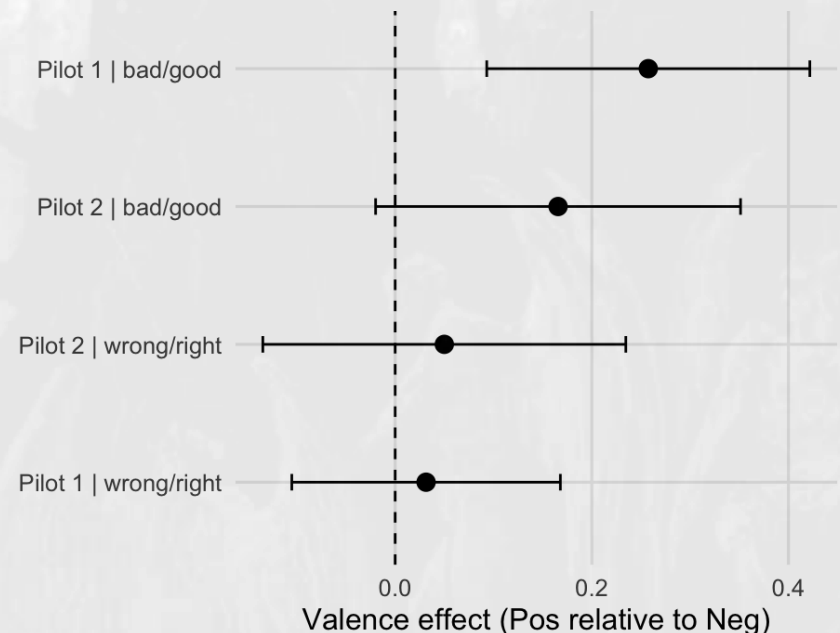
“Is there a correct answer?”

- Small effect in the opposite direction: Positive vignettes were rated as slightly more objective

BUT: Only in the Bad-Good framing

AND: Only in Pilot 1,
 $b = 0.26$, $p = .002$.

Not Pilot 2,
 $b = 0.17$, $p = .081$.

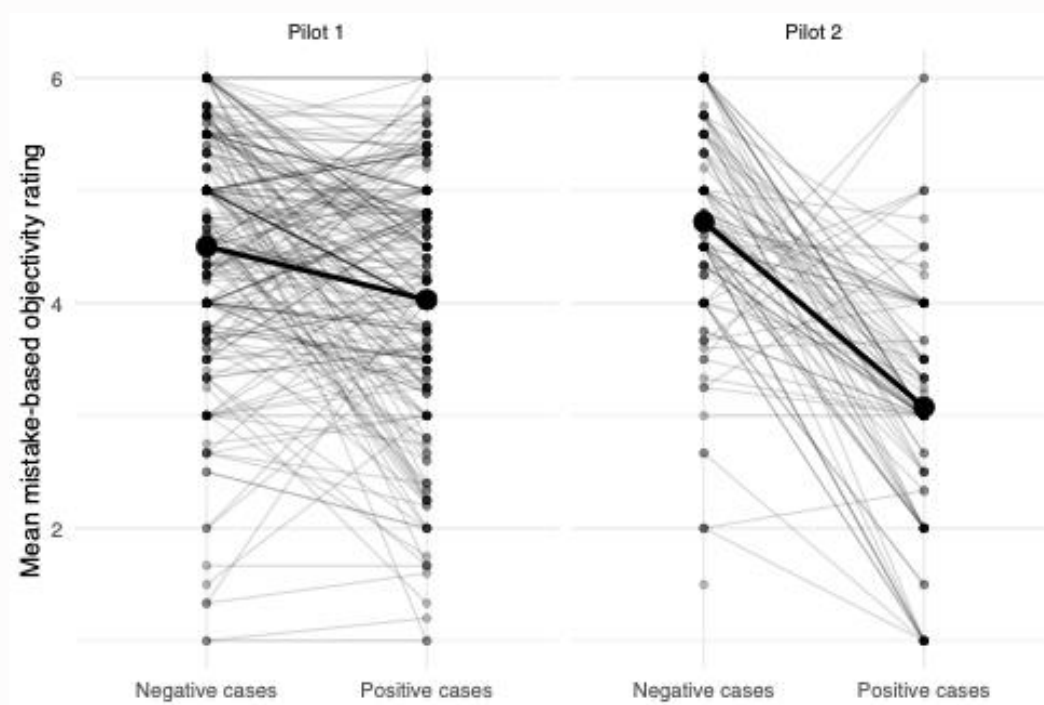


“Is the other person mistaken?”

- No reliable valence effect across all data

Exploratory Analysis: Extreme Responses

- Negative vignettes were perceived as more objective (strongest in bad-good framing)



Does Framing Matter?

Unclear whether

- Small, preliminary effects:
 - *Good-bad frame led to more extreme responses*
- Only impacted “is there a correct answer”?
- Only found in Pilot 1
 - Positive reported as more objective
 - More extreme responding compared to right-wrong
 - Not replicated in Pilot 2

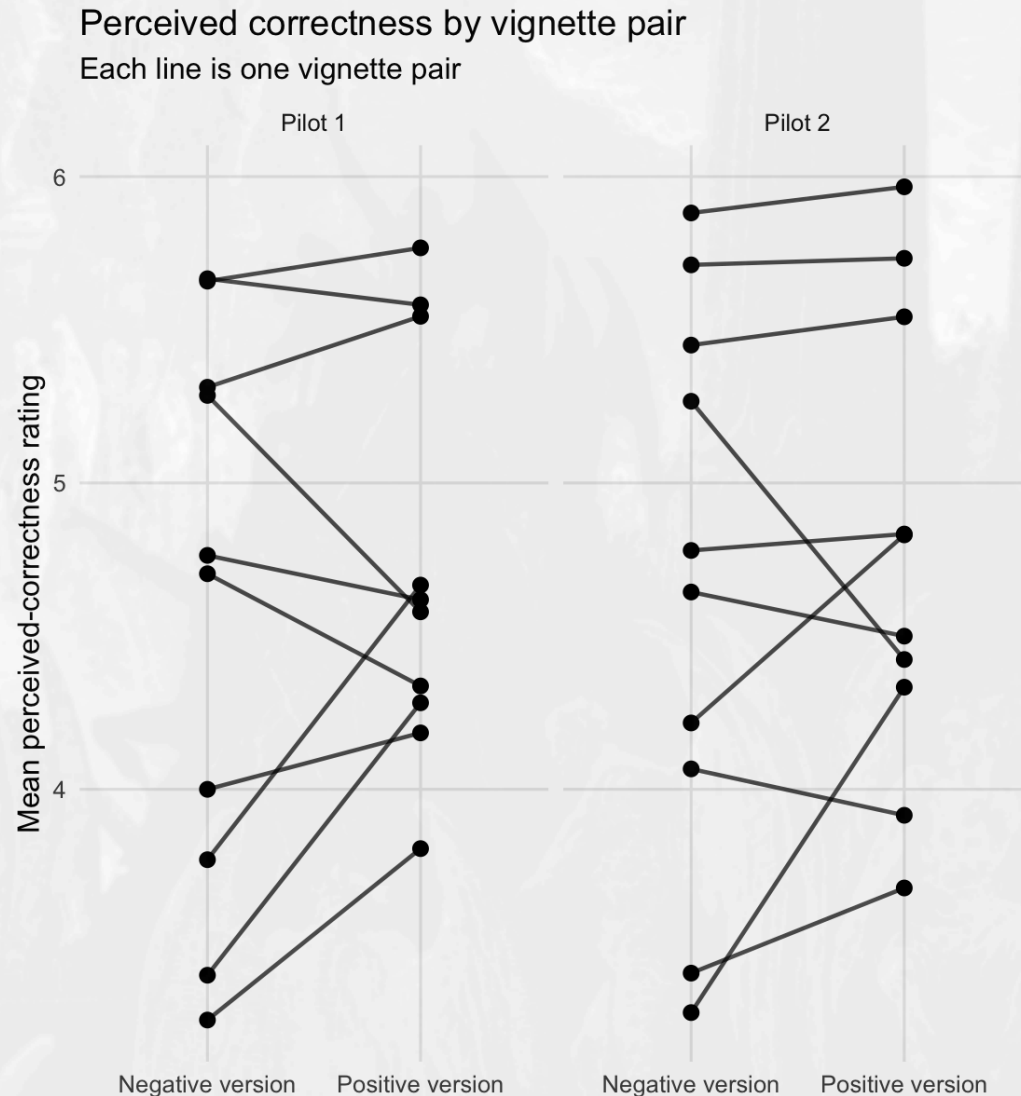
Other Factors: Consensus and Ease

Higher *perceived consensus* and *easier judgements* predicted higher objectivity ratings

- When perceived agreement and ease were added to the model, the valence effect on objectivity (“correct answer”) disappeared (Pilot 1)
- Perceived agreement and ease also predicted disagreement judgment, but they did not explain that pattern away in the same way.

Moral Vignettes: Item Heterogeneity

- The vignettes did not all behave the same way
- Heterogeneity somewhat consistent across pilots



Limitations

- Some effects are small and not fully replicated
- Pilot 1 had the bad/good midpoint labeling problem
- Item heterogeneity is substantial
- Q5 effect is strongest in the extreme subset, not uniformly across all trials
- Consensus and ease are measured, not manipulated
- The current pilots do not establish causality

Limitations: Vignette Design

- Is the opposite of *donating* being *stingy*, or *stealing*?
- What is the opposite of *punching*?

Future Directions

- Better vignette pairs
- Other variables:
 - Action (vs. inaction), types of action, arousal of vignette
 - Actor intention, actor control,
- Systematic progression from controlled and pared back vignettes to real-world examples
- Analysing the impact of evaluative language (e.g., “steal” vs “take”)
- Cross-language bilingual replication



Thank you
for your time!

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References

Diogenes (n.d.). [personal communication via a dream]

Goodwin, G. P., & Darley, J. M. (2012). Why are some moral beliefs perceived to be more objective than others?. *Journal of Experimental Social Psychology*, 48(1), 250-256.